

# WOOD VENEER, MELAMINE & HPL CUT EDGE & CORNER COMPARISON

A practical material guide for retail fixtures, display cabinets and shopfitting

**The surface may look similar. The edge tells the real story.**

Prepared for international clients of ONI Display / ONI Shopfitting

[www.onidisplay.com](http://www.onidisplay.com) | [www.onishopfitting.com](http://www.onishopfitting.com)



# 1. THE DIFFERENCE AT A GLANCE

CUT EDGE + CORNER LOGIC

## CUT EDGE & CORNER COMPARISON



### CLIENT-FACING SUMMARY

Wood veneer can be wrapped, grain-matched and coated for the most visually unified corner. Melamine/LPL is a pre-finished board: cutting exposes the substrate, so a separate edge band is required. Standard HPL is a thicker sheet bonded to a substrate; a straight-cut edge still needs a separate finish, although selected postforming grades can wrap a radius.





### REAL WOOD SURFACE

## Wrapped. Matched. Finished as one.

- **Construction**

A thin slice of real wood is bonded to MDF, plywood or another stable substrate, then sanded, stained and clear-coated.

- **Edge treatment**

The veneer can wrap a small radius, or the edge can receive matching veneer. Grain selection, sanding and coating visually blend the junction.

- **What the customer sees**

Natural grain variation and a softer, furniture-grade corner. The joint exists, but skilled finishing makes it much less prominent.

- **Best use**

Premium boutique counters, jewelry and eyewear showcases, feature walls, reception desks and brand-led furniture.

### IMPORTANT

Veneer is not automatically seamless. The integrated appearance depends on substrate preparation, balanced construction, matching veneer, controlled adhesive application, edge workmanship and a consistent coating system.





#### COST-EFFICIENT SURFACE

## Cut it - then seal the exposed core.

- **Construction**

Melamine-resin-impregnated decorative paper is thermally fused directly to particleboard or MDF. No secondary sheet lamination is required.

- **At the cut edge**

Machining exposes the particleboard or MDF core. The edge must be protected with ABS, PVC, PP, wood veneer or another specified edging.

- **What the customer sees**

A fine joint line normally remains between the face and the edge band. Decor, texture and gloss differences can remain even when the color reference is matched.

- **Best use**

Cabinet carcasses, doors, back panels, low-to-moderate contact shelving, office furniture and cost-sensitive rollout programs.

#### TYPICAL COMMERCIAL FORMAT

Example manufacturer range: EGGER Eurodekor MFC is offered in multiple board thicknesses; a commonly stocked specification is 18 mm. The surface conforms to EN 14322. Board thickness and edging must be selected project by project.





### HIGH-WEAR APPLICATIONS

## More durable - but the edge still matters.

- **Construction**

Decor paper and multiple resin-impregnated kraft layers are consolidated under high heat and pressure. The resulting sheet is bonded to MDF, plywood or particleboard.

- **Standard or 45-degree joint**

HPL may be joined directly or with a 45-degree mitre. Because the phenolic kraft core is normally dark, a fine black line can remain at the junction.

- **Postforming exception**

Selected postforming grades can be heated and wrapped around a prepared radius, reducing the front-edge seam. This is grade- and process-specific.

- **Best use**

Cash-wrap counters, worktops, high-contact shelves, healthcare and food-service fixtures, and other high-wear horizontal or vertical surfaces.

### REFERENCE VALUES - FORMICA EXAMPLES

Thin HPL examples: approximately 0.7-1.2 mm depending on grade. Postforming HGP/VGP guidance: 163-177 C. A fine dark core line at direct or mitred joints is normal and should be accepted on the physical sample before production.



## 5. TECHNICAL COMPARISON

TYPICAL VALUES - VERIFY THE SELECTED PRODUCT

| Category               | Natural wood veneer                                    | Melamine / LPL / TFL                                | HPL laminate                                                    |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Surface build          | Real wood leaf + adhesive + coating                    | Melamine decor paper fused to board                 | Decor + resin kraft layers, bonded to board                     |
| Typical face thickness | Broad typical range about 0.3-2.5 mm; product-specific | Very thin integrated paper/resin surface            | Common thin sheet examples about 0.7-1.2 mm                     |
| After cutting          | Core is exposed before veneering/finishing             | Core is exposed                                     | Laminate layers + substrate are exposed                         |
| Typical edge solution  | Wrapped/matched veneer, solid lipping, mitre           | ABS/PVC/PP or matching edge band                    | Direct joint, 45-degree mitre, HPL strip or ABS/PVC             |
| Joint visibility       | Lowest when well matched and coated                    | Fine band line normally visible                     | Fine dark/black core line may remain at direct or mitred joints |
| Corner options         | Small-radius wrap; matched joint; mitre                | Primarily separate banding; shaped profiles limited | Straight edge; mitre; selected postforming grades               |
| Wear resistance        | Coating-dependent; repairable/refinishable             | Moderate; suited to general furniture use           | Generally highest of these thin decorative surfaces             |
| Cost position          | Highest workmanship and finishing input                | Most economical for volume production               | Higher surface and fabrication cost than LPL                    |
| Best fit               | Premium visual continuity                              | Value, consistency and fast rollout                 | High-contact and high-wear applications                         |

Note: 'Fireproof board' is a common market name for HPL, but not every HPL product or composite assembly has the same certified fire classification.



### The edge is only one part of the material decision.

#### AUTHENTICITY

Real veneer is genuine timber. Natural grain, tone and figure vary from panel to panel; this variation is part of its premium character.

#### UNIFORMITY

Laminate uses a printed decorative surface. Repeated sheets are more predictable for chain stores and volume rollouts.

#### CARE + REPAIR

Veneer needs a suitable protective coating and more care. Minor surface wear may sometimes be sanded and refinished, subject to veneer thickness.

#### DURABILITY

Laminate is generally more resistant to scratches, stains and routine moisture exposure, and is easier to clean in high-use environments.

#### COLOUR OVER TIME

Natural timber can darken, fade or shift under UV exposure. UV-resistant coatings and controlled lighting reduce - but do not eliminate - change.

#### BUDGET + SPEED

Laminate is normally less expensive and faster to standardise. Veneer requires real timber selection, matching, finishing and skilled workmanship.



#### SUPPORTING VIDEO EXPLAINER

Wood Veneer VS Wood Laminate Kitchen Cabinets | What's the Difference - The Kitchen Store. Use the video as a customer-friendly overview; confirm project details from the approved sample and product data sheets.

[youtube.com/watch?v=FhQRDVGc-8&t=227s](https://youtube.com/watch?v=FhQRDVGc-8&t=227s)



## 7. EDGE DETAIL DRIVES THE FINISHED LOOK

SPECIFY THE EDGE - NOT ONLY THE DECOR

### 01 WRAPPED / MATCHED VENEER

Best visual continuity. Requires skilled matching, sanding and coating. Ideal for premium fixtures.

### 02 ABS / PVC EDGE BAND

Fast, economical and replaceable. Joint line and texture variation may remain visible.

### 03 HPL DIRECT JOINT / 45-DEGREE MITRE

Hard-wearing and crisp. A fine black phenolic-core line can remain at either joint and must be approved on the sample.

### 04 POSTFORMED HPL

Reduces the front seam on a radius. Requires postforming-grade laminate, heat control and the correct substrate profile.

#### PUT THESE ITEMS ON THE APPROVAL SAMPLE

Decor code and texture | Substrate and thickness | Edge method: direct or 45-degree mitre | Acceptable dark-line visibility | Edge material and thickness | Corner radius | Grain direction | Adhesive and coating | Moisture detail



## 8. FROM MATERIAL SAMPLE TO FINISHED FIXTURE

ONI APPLICATION EXAMPLES



BOUTIQUE DISPLAY ENVIRONMENT



PHARMACY RETAIL FIXTURE ENVIRONMENT



FURNITURE SHOWROOM INSTALLATION



COMMERCIAL JOINERY INSTALLATION



### Choose WOOD VENEER when...

premium appearance, natural variation, grain continuity and a furniture-grade corner are the priority.

### Choose MELAMINE / LPL when...

cost control, repeatable decor, rapid production and low-to-moderate duty use are the priority.

### Choose HPL when...

abrasion, impact, cleaning frequency and high-contact commercial use justify the extra surface and fabrication cost.

### THE SIMPLEST CLIENT EXPLANATION

Veneer can be finished to look continuous around the corner. Melamine needs a separate edge band after cutting. HPL can use a direct joint or 45-degree mitre, but a fine black core line may remain. It is not practical to hand-retouch every production joint, so the client must approve this appearance on the sample.

#### Technical references

ONI HPL vs LPL guide | Formica Group laminate and postforming guides | EGGER Eurodekor literature | Bord Products: Timber Veneer vs Laminate | WoodenAve: Veneer vs. Laminate | The Kitchen Store video: FhQRDVGc-8 | Product families reference EN 438 (HPL) and EN 14322 (melamine-faced boards).